Delhi and Kabul, and even helped in its growth.[135] The depth of R&AW's links with the KhAD became increasingly public when in April 1988 an alert security guard at the Palam Airport in Delhi saw some stray bullets fall from a crate when the cargo of Indian Airlines flight IC-452 from Kabul to New Delhi was being unloaded. An x-ray examination revealed a full cache of weapons including rocket launchers of the type that the Mujahideen were using in Afghanistan.

Curiously, before the head of security at the airport could check the contents in detail an R&AW operative whisked all crates away saying that they were government property. Within a month, the rocket launchers were found with Khalistani militants near Kalanur in the Gurdaspur district of Punjab. The news sent a shock wave across the country and rocked the parliament.[136] Was this an R&AW conspiracy or had the ISI infiltrated the Indian system so deeply that it could use an Indian passenger airliner to send weapons to arm Khalistani militants? General (Retd) Jagjit Singh Aurora of the 1971 India-Pakistan war fame, now a Rajya Sabha MP from Punjab, led the charge against Rajiv and the R&AW's mysterious activities, and successfully mobilised a wide array of opposition parties including the Janata Party and the BJP to push the government to come clean on its failures in Punjab. If the Afghan and Indian intelligence agencies were indeed collaborating to undertake such operations, it would undermine India's credibility on Punjab and Pakistan's involvement in the same.

The mystery of India's covert involvement in Afghanistan reached a new level when media reports started pouring in of Indian pilots fighting in the 1989 Battle of Jalalabad (between Najibullah's forces and the Mujahideen).[137] The reports raised questions in the parliament, which otherwise had no supervision over India's intelligence agencies.[138] Though the government denied (and still continues to deny) such allegations, a former R&AW officer deeply involved in Afghan affairs, stated that 'Jalalabad was an Indian city' in 1989 and, unlike in 2014, Kabul was somewhat dependent on Indian support to fight its battles.[139] This does not mean (nor does this intelligence officer confirm it as such) that Indian pilots were fighting in Jalalabad, or even were actively involved in supporting the Afghan air force, but it does underline India's intimate security relationship with Afghanistan at that time. By the late 1980s, however, despite